Cross-Architecture Transferability is Width-Confounded: Diagnosis and Subspace Correction

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Abstract

Selecting a pretrained encoder for a downstream task without retraining or labels is a standard preprocessing step in transfer learning. The dominant label-free score, RankMe, was validated within architecture families and is widely applied across them. We show that its cross-architecture use is unsound: rankings are systematically driven by the penultimate-layer dimension rather than representational quality, and on heterogeneous model pools the score performs worse than uniform random selection. We give a random-matrix explanation establishing this failure as inherent to any rotation-invariant score, and propose Subspace-Corrected Ranking (SCR), a family of label-free corrections that breaks rotation invariance by comparing each candidate's target features with its features on a fixed reference dataset; its simplest member $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ corrects log-effective-rank by subtracting log-subspace-alignment with the reference, requiring no labels or hyperparameters. Across MV, VTAB, and the EX pool (23 aggregated task units), $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ reduces mean regret from $+0.161$ (RankMe) to $+0.071$ (95% CI $[+0.045, +0.099]$, paired $p = 0.0002$). Paired with RankMe for within-family variant selection ($\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ $\rightarrow$RankMe), it matches this quality at one-third of the forward-pass cost. Five labelled architecture evaluations suffice to match the best fully label-free strategy; $K{=}35$ labelled evaluations reduce regret to $+0.018$—a $5.7\times$ improvement at the same forward-pass cost. Code: https://anonymous.4open.science/r/crossarchitecturetransferability-FEC8.

1 Introduction

Transfer learning starts with a choice: which pretrained encoder to fine-tune on the target task. When candidate encoders share the same architecture but differ in pretraining recipe, the choice can be made cheaply via a label-free score on the encoder's penultimate features. The dominant such score, *RankMe* [9], computes the effective rank $r_{\mathrm{eff}}(H)$ of the feature matrix and ranks candidates by $\log r_{\mathrm{eff}}$. In the within-architecture setting where RankMe was validated, the penultimate-layer dimension d is constant across candidates and the score reflects representational quality.

The realistic deployment setting is different. A practitioner faced with the timm [31] or torchvision model zoo chooses between fundamentally different backbones—ResNet [11], ViT [6], ConvNeXt [17], EfficientNet [27], and others—whose penultimate dimensions vary by an order of magnitude. RankMe was validated on within-family variants [9]; however, practitioners selecting among heterogeneous backbones on model hubs such as timm [31] and Hugging Face Hub naturally apply it pool-wide, without the within-family stratification its validation assumed. In this cross-architecture setting, we show that RankMe-based selection fails systematically. The rankings it produces are dom-

Submitted to 40th Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS 2026). Do not distribute.

inated by the penultimate-layer width: on a pool of 132 pretrained variants spanning 35 multi-variant architectures, RankMe selects the widest available variant on every task, yielding regret worse than uniform random selection. The same width confound is observed on a 25-architecture VTAB pool, an 8-encoder SSL/multimodal pool, and a 51-variant EX pool spanning 10 tasks. In all four pools, label-free cross-architecture transferability estimation as currently practiced is unsound.

The mechanism is a consequence of feature isotropy and rotation invariance. A Marchenko–Pastur argument shows that for approximately isotropic features the effective rank scales as $\Theta(d)$ in the large-n limit, so $\log r_{\text{eff}}$ converges to $\log d$ plus a quality-independent constant. More generally, any score that is invariant under right-rotations of the feature matrix must reduce to a function of d in this regime; RankMe, von Neumann entropy, and the trace form of H-score are all rotation-invariant.

The fix is to introduce a non-rotation-invariant component into the score. We propose *Subspace-Corrected Ranking* (SCR), a family of label-free scores that compares each candidate encoder's target features with features extracted by the same encoder on a fixed reference dataset. Across the candidate pool, SA_k correlates strongly negatively ($\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}} = -0.96$) with the fraction of class-mean variance lying in the candidate's architecture-specific subspace. Subtracting the alignment therefore preferentially rewards candidates whose discriminative variance is not absorbed into the generic subspace, and it does so without using labels. The default member, $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger} = [\log r_{\text{eff}} - \log \mathrm{SA}_k]/\log C$, halves regret over RankMe in cross-architecture flat selection, and a non-adaptive two-stage pipeline that uses $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ at the architecture level and RankMe within-family matches flat-$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ quality at one-third the forward-pass cost. A small label budget at the architecture-selection stage closes most of the remaining gap to supervised model-selection quality.

Contributions. **(i) Diagnosis.** We prove that any rotation-invariant label-free score degrades to ranking by feature dimension under near-isotropy (Lemma 1, Corollary 2), and confirm this across 132 timm variants [31], 25 VTAB architectures [33], 8 SSL encoders spanning contrastive [4, 12], self-distillation [3], and vision–language [24] pretraining, and 51 supervised variants in the EX pool. **(ii) Correction.** We propose Subspace-Corrected Ranking (SCR), a family of label-free scores that break rotation invariance by aligning each candidate's target features with its features on a fixed reference dataset, with geometric support: $\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(\mathrm{SA}_k, f_{\mathrm{spe}}) = -0.96$ on 126 architecture–task pairs. **(iii) Pipeline.** We design a two-stage architecture→variant pipeline achieving $3.1\times$ cost savings over flat scoring without quality loss, and a mixed-budget variant where just $K{=}5$ labelled evaluations match the best label-free quality. **(iv) Benchmark.** Four reproducible evaluation pools covering 52 task units across supervised and SSL/multimodal pretraining paradigms, with backbone widths spanning $d \in [192, 4096]$. The pools are deliberately calibrated at three distinct $d_{\max}/d_{\min}$ ratios ($5.3\times$, $10.7\times$, $21.3\times$), exposing the regimes in which existing corrections succeed or fail and providing a diagnostic testbed for future label-free transferability scores. Pre-computed features, all result tables, and scoring code are released for community use.

2 Related Work

Label-free transferability scores. RankMe [9] ranks pretrained encoders by the effective rank of penultimate features, using $p_i = \sigma_i / \sum_j \sigma_j$; it was validated within ViT and ResNet family variants but has since been applied in the community to heterogeneous model pools (timm rankings, multi-architecture VTAB evaluations) without the within-family stratification under which its validity was established—the gap this paper addresses. VNE [14] instead uses the entropy of normalised squared singular values. The two scores are distinct spectral functionals, but both are rotation-invariant and therefore share the width-confounding mechanism analysed here. DiSCO [34] computes effective rank on class-conditional feature covariances, partially correcting for per-class spectral inflation; it appears in our experiments as the strongest existing label-free baseline. Label-requiring scores—LogME [32], H-score [2], NCTI [30], LEEP [20], N-LEEP [16], PACTran [5], OTCE [28], GBC [23], TransRate [13], NCE [29], and Task2Vec [1]—trade label cost for accuracy and integrate naturally as the supervised stage of our two-stage pipeline. Transfer learning more broadly has a rich history surveyed in Pan and Yang [22]; our work addresses the specific problem of cross-architecture pre-selection in the modern model-zoo setting.

Subspace alignment and random matrix theory. Subspace alignment [8] was introduced for unsupervised domain adaptation via principal-angle geometry on the Grassmann manifold [10]. Neural network representation similarity via CKA and SVCCA [15, 25] uses related geometric ideas

to compare layers; we use it differently here, as a label-free measure of generic-vs-specific feature structure relative to a fixed reference dataset encoded by each candidate. The Marchenko–Pastur law [19] has been applied to characterise weight matrices in deep networks [18]; we apply it directly to feature matrices to derive the width-confound mechanism.

Two-stage and budgeted model selection. Staged screening followed by precise evaluation is a standard design in neural architecture search and Bayesian hyper-parameter optimisation. In source-free transferability estimation [30, 32], the same logic supports a cross-architecture stage at low cost followed by a within-family stage; our contribution is the formal cost–quality analysis of such pipelines and the mixed-budget variant in which a small label budget is allocated only to the architecture-selection stage.

3 Setup

Pools. We use four architecturally distinct pools whose descriptions are summarised in Table 1 (full per-pool details in Appendices B–E). **MV pool** (multi-variant pool; 132 timm [31] variants, 35 multi-variant architectures, 5 tasks) is the only pool with multiple variants per architecture and is therefore the only pool on which two-stage pipelines are evaluated. **VTAB pool** [33] (25 architectures, 8 tasks) is single-variant and broader in target diversity. **SSL pool** (8 SSL/multimodal encoders including CLIP [24], DINOv2 [21], DINO [3], and MoCo [12]; 29 tasks) uses pretraining-objective diversity on a smaller set of backbones. **EX pool** (extended supervised pool; 51 timm variants from 35 canonical architectures including VGG-16, d=4096; 10 tasks: CIFAR-10/100, DTD, EuroSAT, Fashion-MNIST, FGVC-Aircraft, Flowers-102, Food-101, Oxford-Pets, SVHN) covers the same $d_{\max}/d_{\min}$=21.3× width span as MV pool with a single canonical variant per architecture and broader task coverage; all variants are ImageNet-1k supervised, features extracted on the full dataset. Across the four pools we cover 52 task units and architectures with penultimate dimensions $d \in [192, 4096]$.

Table 1: Four architecturally distinct evaluation pools used throughout the paper. The $d_{\max}/d_{\min}$ spread drives the severity of the width confound and the choice of correction (see §7).

Pool	Archs	Variants	Tasks	d range	$d_{\max}/d_{\min}$
MV pool (multi-variant)	35	119 (multi-var.) / 132 (full)	5	[192, 4096]	21.3×
VTAB pool	25	25	8	[192, 2048]	10.7×
SSL/multimodal pool	8	8	29	[384, 2048]	5.3×
EX pool (supv.)	35	51	10	[192, 4096]	21.3×

Scores. Effective rank r_{eff} is computed by the RankMe formula [9]: $p_i = \sigma_i / \sum_j \sigma_j$ and $r_{\text{eff}} = \exp(-\sum_i p_i \log p_i)$. For each candidate encoder m, subspace alignment SA_k at k=20 [8] compares its target features $H_{m,T}$ with its STL-10 features $H_{m,D_{\text{ref}}}$. Thus STL-10 is a fixed reference *dataset*; no right-singular-vector comparison is made across encoders with different feature dimensions. We benchmark against DiSCO [34] (label-free, class-conditional r_{eff}), LogME [32] and H-score [2] (label-based feature spectrum), and LEEP [20] and NCTI [30] (label-based class distribution).

Linear-probe ground truth. We use the held-out accuracy (lp_acc) of ℓ_2-regularised logistic regression with C=1 on a single 80/20 split. Strategy quality is reported as *regret*, the gap to the per-task oracle accuracy. Confidence intervals are obtained by task-level bootstrap with n_{boot}=10 000 resamples; paired bootstrap for head-to-head comparisons.

4 The Width Confound

We isolate the failure mechanism with two formal statements. Both proofs are in Appendix A.

Lemma 1 (Marchenko–Pastur scaling)**.** *Let $H \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times d}$ have i.i.d. rows from $\mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2 I_d)$. As $n, d \to \infty$ with $\gamma = n/d$ fixed, $r_{\text{eff}}(H)/d \to c(\gamma) > 0$ almost surely, where $c(\gamma)$ depends only on the aspect ratio. In particular $r_{\text{eff}}(H) = \Theta(d)$.*

Corollary 2 (Rotation-invariant scorers reduce to d-ranking)**.** *If $S(H)$ satisfies $S(HQ) = S(H)$ for all $Q \in O(d)$ and each architecture's features are approximately isotropic, then S converges to a monotone function of d alone. Flat selection by S therefore ranks architectures by feature dimension.*

Proposition 3 ($\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ is not rotation-invariant)**.** *For candidate encoder m, under $H_{m,T} \mapsto H_{m,T}Q$ with $Q \in O(d_m)$ while $H_{m,D_{\mathrm{ref}}}$ remains fixed, the right singular vectors transform as $V_{m,T} \mapsto Q^{\top}V_{m,T}$, changing their principal angles to $V_{m,\mathrm{ref}}$ and hence SA_k. Consequently $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}(H_{m,T}Q, T) \neq \mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}(H_{m,T}, T)$ in general.*

The corollary applies to RankMe, VNE [14] and the trace form of H-score [2]; all three are rotation-invariant and degrade to d-ranking under approximate isotropy. Proposition 3 establishes the converse property that any candidate correction must satisfy: subspace alignment with a fixed reference dataset is the geometric mechanism that re-introduces architecture-specific information into the score. Empirically, on the EX pool (51 variants) the Kendall rank correlation between RankMe and d is $\tau = +0.617$ (mean across 10 tasks; all $p < 10^{-4}$), confirming the predicted near-concordance. Near-isotropy itself is verified by measuring the Gaussian equicovariance violation η_{Σ}: 93% of (architecture, task) pairs satisfy $\eta_{\Sigma} < 0.1$ (Appendix A).

Empirical confound across pools. On MV pool the per-task Spearman correlation $\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(\mathrm{RankMe}, d)$ has mean $+0.61$ across the 5 tasks; on the VTAB pool the mean is $+0.882$ (Table 2 uses full-dataset VTAB features; the cross-pool aggregation in Table 7 uses n=1000 subsampled features for SA_k computation consistency); on the SSL pool the mean is $+0.815$. Crucially, d itself does *not* predict linear-probe accuracy: $\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(d, \mathrm{lp_acc})$ is -0.10 on MV pool, -0.45 on the SSL pool, and nominally $+0.20$ on VTAB—elevated by SVHN (a digit-recognition task where capacity genuinely helps, ρ=$+0.856$); excluding STL-10 (reference task) and SVHN, the VTAB median falls to $+0.02$, consistent with the other pools. Across all three pools, d acts as a pure confound rather than a quality signal. Flat-RankMe regret exceeds uniform random regret in all four pools (Table 2; EX pool: Appendix E). On MV pool, RankMe selects `vgg16` (d=4096) on every one of the 5 tasks, yielding regret 0.125 LP points worse than random. MV pool's CNN-only sub-pool reproduces this behaviour (`vgg16` chosen on $4/5$ tasks, Appendix B), confirming that the confound is not a ViT-vs-CNN artefact.

Table 2: Width confound across MV, VTAB, and SSL pools (EX pool diagnosis data in Appendix E). RankMe correlates strongly with d (large positive ρ_{Sp}) yet d itself does not predict quality (near-zero or negative $\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(d, \mathrm{lp_acc})$), confirming that d is a confound rather than a signal.

Pool	Arch., tasks	$\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(\mathrm{RankMe}, d)$	$\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(d, \mathrm{lp_acc})$	RankMe regret	Random regret
MV pool	35, 5	$+0.61$	-0.10	$+0.319$	$+0.194$
VTAB	25, 8	$+0.882$	$+0.20$	$+0.083$	$+0.064$
SSL	8, 29	$+0.815$	-0.45	$+0.103$	$+0.066$

VTAB per-task breakdown. On the VTAB pool the width confound is equally systematic: Table 3 shows that Flat-RankMe selects the highest-d available architecture on *all* 8 VTAB tasks without exception. Despite the absence of VGG-class encoders (maximum d=2048), the per-task Spearman correlation $\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(\mathrm{RankMe}, d)$ ranges from $+0.838$ to $+0.915$, and per-task regret ranges from $+0.020$ (Fashion-MNIST, near-uniform pixel data where feature quality matters little) to $+0.200$ (Flowers-102, fine-grained texture).

Table 3: VTAB per-task width confound. Flat-RankMe regret $+0.083$ (mean), suboptimal on all $8/8$ tasks; $\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(\mathrm{RankMe}, d)$ is large and positive on every task.

Task	$\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(\mathrm{RankMe}, d)$	Regret	RankMe pick
CIFAR-10	$+0.874$	$+0.050$	efficientnet_b3 (d=1536)
CIFAR-100	$+0.869$	$+0.155$	efficientnet_b3 (d=1536)
DTD	$+0.877$	$+0.085$	resnet101 (d=2048)
Fashion-MNIST	$+0.886$	$+0.020$	wide_resnet50_2 (d=2048)
Flowers-102	$+0.838$	$+0.200$	efficientnet_b3 (d=1536)
Pets	$+0.902$	$+0.030$	mobilenetv3_large (d=1280)
STL-10	$+0.892$	$+0.025$	efficientnet_b2 (d=1408)
SVHN	$+0.915$	$+0.100$	efficientnet_b3 (d=1536)
Mean	$\mathbf{+0.882}$	$\mathbf{+0.083}$	—

Severity is driven by inter-architecture width variance. The MV pool failure is sharpest because the pool spans $d \in [192, 4096]$, with VGG-16 occupying the high-d tail. Removing the three VGG variants ($\sim 3\%$ of the pool) shifts Flat-RankMe regret by -0.175 LP, bringing it close to random (Table 6); the same removal does not change $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$'s behaviour because subspace alignment is approximately invariant to which architectures occupy the wide-feature tail. This robustness contrast generalises: rotation-invariant scorers (RankMe, LogME, H-score) all collapse onto a single architecture when a wide outlier is present, while $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ and DiSCO continue to choose task-appropriate variants. At a per-task level (Table 4), Flat-RankMe selects `vgg16` on every MV pool task while $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ selects the task-appropriate variant within 0.07 LP of the oracle on $4/5$ tasks.

Table 4: Per-task breakdown of Flat-RankMe and Flat-$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ on MV pool's multi-variant subset. RankMe selects `vgg16` on every task; $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ recovers task-appropriate architectures.

Task	Oracle	Random	Flat-RM	Flat-$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$	RM picks	$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ picks	Oracle arch
CIFAR-10	0.970	0.785	0.550	0.870	vgg16	resnet50	convnext_base
CIFAR-100	0.825	0.484	0.180	0.670	vgg16	resnet152	convnext_base
DTD	0.740	0.564	0.445	0.720	vgg16	convnext_base	convnext_base
EuroSAT	0.955	0.881	0.765	0.905	vgg16	efficientnet_b3	densenet201
SVHN	0.615	0.430	0.570	0.450	vgg16	efficientnet_b3	densenet169

An independent confirmation via spectral truncation. Recomputing r_{eff} on the top-D truncated singular spectrum of each candidate provides an independent check that the confound lives in the singular-value tail. At $D{=}256$ on MV pool, the per-task Spearman correlation $\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(r_{\mathrm{eff},D=256}, d)$ drops from $+0.63$ (full spectrum) to $+0.06$, and Flat-RankMe regret drops from $+0.319$ to $+0.094$, comparable to $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$. Truncation is not a viable correction for two-stage use, however: small-d architectures (ViT-tiny, DeiT-tiny, both $d{=}192$) are not truncated at all and retain the width ordering; the corresponding stage-1 regret on the multi-variant subset is $+0.204$, more than twice that of $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ (Appendix E).

The confound spans label-free and trace-form label-based scores. Computing a broader set of selection scores on MV pool (Table 5) shows that LogME and the trace form of H-score—both label-based but acting on raw feature-spectrum statistics—also select `vgg16` on every task and degrade by similar margins. Class-distribution scores (LEEP, NCTI), which are not feature-spectrum functionals, are unaffected. This pattern is consistent with Corollary 2: the failure mode is not specific to label-free scoring but specific to rotation-invariant feature-spectrum functionals, regardless of whether they additionally use labels.

Table 5: MV pool SOTA flat comparison (132v×5t). Columns report per-task mean regret with and without the three VGG variants in the pool. Feature-spectrum scores (RankMe, LogME, H-score) all select `vgg16` when present and degrade similarly; class-distribution scores (LEEP, NCTI) and the proposed $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ are robust.

Method	With VGG	Without VGG	Δ	Type
Random	$+0.194$	$+0.193$	-0.001	—
Flat-RankMe	$+0.319$	$+0.144$	-0.175	label-free
Flat-LogME	$+0.319$	$+0.550$	$+0.231$	label-based
Flat-H-score	$+0.319$	$+0.470$	$+0.151$	label-based
Flat-NCTI	$+0.162$	$+0.155$	-0.007	label-based
Flat-DiSCO	$+0.108$	$+0.108$	0.000	label-free
Flat-$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$	$\mathbf{+0.098}$	$\mathbf{+0.098}$	**0.000**	**label-free**
Flat-LEEP	$+0.038$	$+0.038$	0.000	label-based

5 Subspace-Corrected Ranking

Geometric premise. For candidate encoder m, let $V_{m,\mathrm{ref},1:k}$ be the top-k right singular vectors of its features $H_{m,D_{\mathrm{ref}}}$ on the fixed reference dataset, and write $P = V_{m,\mathrm{ref},1:k} V_{m,\mathrm{ref},1:k}^{\top}$, $Q = I - P$.

Table 6: Sensitivity of flat strategies to the presence of VGG-class features (d=4096) in MV pool. Columns report mean LP across the 5 tasks. RankMe and the trace-spectrum label-based scores are dominated by VGG when present; SSR‡, DiSCO, and class-distribution scores (LEEP, NCTI) are robust.

Method	With VGG	Without VGG	Δ	Type
Random	0.629	0.630	+0.001	—
Flat-RankMe	0.502	0.677	+0.175	label-free
Flat-NormRankMe ($-\log d$)	0.600	0.449	−0.151	label-free
Flat-SSR‡	**0.723**	**0.723**	**+0.000**	label-free
Flat-DiSCO	0.713	0.713	+0.000	label-free
Flat-LogME	0.502	0.271	−0.231	label-based
Flat-H-score	0.502	0.351	−0.151	label-based
Flat-LEEP	0.783	0.783	+0.000	label-based
Flat-NCTI	0.659	0.666	+0.007	label-based

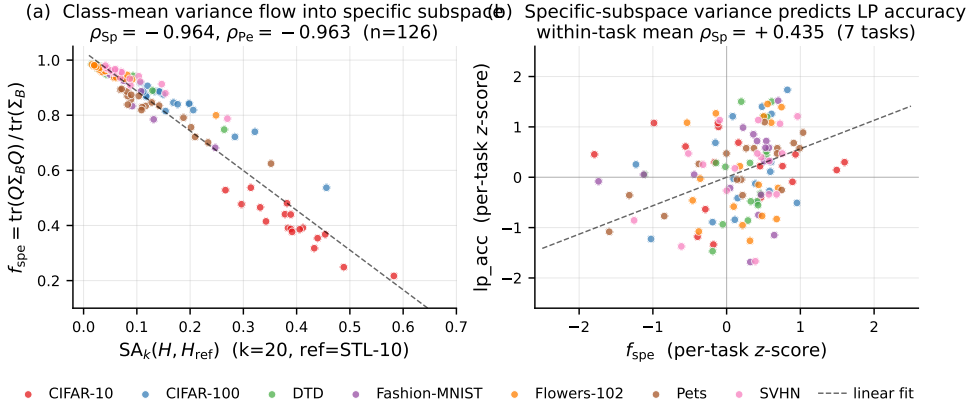


Figure 1: (a) Subspace alignment SA_k between a candidate encoder and the reference (STL-10) is nearly perfectly anti-correlated with the fraction of class-mean variance in the architecture-specific subspace, f_{spe}. (b) Within-task, f_{spe} predicts linear-probe accuracy.

Define

$$f_{\mathrm{spe}}(H, H_{\mathrm{ref}}) := \frac{\mathrm{tr}(Q\Sigma_B Q)}{\mathrm{tr}(\Sigma_B)},$$

the fraction of between-class covariance lying outside the reference subspace. f_{spe} measures how much of a candidate's discriminative variance is architecture-specific rather than shared with a generic encoder. On the VTAB pool (126 architecture–task pairs), the subspace alignment $\mathrm{SA}_k(H, H_{\mathrm{ref}})$ is nearly perfectly anti-correlated with f_{spe} ($\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}} = -0.964$, all 7 tasks $\rho < -0.86$, Figure 1). Within each task, f_{spe} predicts LP accuracy with mean Spearman $\rho = +0.435$. Subtracting subspace alignment is therefore a label-free way to penalise candidates whose discriminative variance is absorbed by the generic subspace. The analysis covers 126 of the 25×7=175 non-reference architecture–task pairs: `resnet152` has a numerical SA_k failure (rank-deficient under n=1000 sampling), leaving 168 valid SA_k pairs; f_{spe} further requires full between-class covariance matrices, available for 18 of the 25 architectures (126 = 18×7 pairs; see `results/vtab_fspe_analysis.csv`).

Method family. Subspace-Corrected Ranking is the family

$$\mathrm{SCR}(H, T; \beta, g) := \frac{\log r_{\mathrm{eff}}(H) + \beta \cdot g\big(\mathrm{SA}_k(H, H_{\mathrm{ref}})\big)}{\log C(T)},$$

where g is a monotonically decreasing function and $\beta \geq 0$. Choosing $g(s) = -\log s$ with $\beta = 1$ gives

$$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}(H, T) := \frac{\log r_{\mathrm{eff}}(H) - \log \mathrm{SA}_k(H, H_{\mathrm{ref}})}{\log C(T)},$$

and $g(s) = 1 - s$ with a constant β gives the additive variant. For per-task ranking, the common positive factor $1/\log C(T)$ may be omitted without changing the selected model. Both forms break rotation invariance via Proposition 3. Across MV pool, VTAB, and the EX pool, the optimal β^* for the additive variant lies in the same plateau $[10, 30]$ on all three pools (Table 11 in Appendix F), and the resulting regret matches $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ within 0.005 LP across pools. The cross-pool agreement of the optimal scaling identifies the SCR correction as a single mechanism realised by either functional form, rather than an artefact of any specific algebraic choice. We adopt $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ as the default member because it is parameter-free.

Choice of reference dataset. All main-text experiments use STL-10 as the reference dataset for SA_k; every candidate encoder separately extracts its own STL-10 reference features. STL-10 is a generic 10-class object dataset, out-of-distribution relative to the seven non-STL VTAB target tasks, and small enough to extract on the model zoo cheaply. Comparing three candidate references on the VTAB pool, STL-10 yields regret $+0.066$, CIFAR-10 yields $+0.098$, and Flowers-102 yields $+0.013$ but is itself a target task and the low value reflects in-distribution leakage rather than method strength (Appendix D). Replacing the single reference with the median over a 4-reference ensemble (STL-10, CIFAR-10, Flowers-102, Pets) reduces VTAB $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ regret to $+0.051$. We adopt the single-reference STL-10 throughout the main experiments to keep the method parameter-light; the ensemble is described in Appendix D.

Cross-pool evaluation. We aggregate 23 task units across MV pool (5), VTAB (8, n=1000 subsampled features), and the EX pool (10) and compute task-level bootstrap CIs (Table 7). Aggregating across architecturally distinct pools tightens single-pool intervals by an order of magnitude. $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ achieves regret $+0.071$ $[+0.045, +0.099]$, compared with DiSCO's $+0.108$, RankMe's $+0.161$, and uniform random's $+0.129$. The improvement of $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ over RankMe is $\Delta = -0.095$ (95% CI $[-0.161, -0.037]$, $p = 0.0002$, paired bootstrap); over DiSCO the trend is favourable but not significant on n=15 paired tasks ($\Delta = -0.035$, $p = 0.154$). The cross-pool test establishes that $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ consistently outperforms RankMe across architecturally distinct pools: the improvement is not a pool-specific artefact but persists whether the pool varies primarily in backbone width (MV) or in target-task diversity (VTAB, EX pool).

Task-independence note. Eight task names (CIFAR-10/100, DTD, EuroSAT, SVHN, Fashion-MNIST, Flowers-102, Pets) appear in more than one pool. Each (task-name, pool) combination is a distinct model-selection problem with a different candidate set, so the 23 task units are not correlated replicates of the same observation. As an additional robustness check, a Wilcoxon signed-rank test on all 22 paired task units (excluding STL-10 where $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ is undefined as the reference task) gives $p = 0.0036$, consistent with the bootstrap result.

Table 7: Cross-pool flat-strategy evaluation. 23 task units pooled across MV pool, VTAB, and the EX pool; task-level bootstrap CIs (n_{boot}=10 000).

Method	Mean regret	95% CI	CI width
Random	$+0.129$	$[+0.098, +0.163]$	0.064
Flat-RankMe	$+0.161$	$[+0.105, +0.228]$	0.122
Flat-DiSCO	$+0.108$	$[+0.059, +0.163]$	0.104
Flat-$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$	$\mathbf{+0.071}$	$[\mathbf{+0.045}, \mathbf{+0.099}]$	**0.054**
Paired $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ vs. RankMe: $\Delta = -0.095$, 95% CI $[-0.161, -0.037]$, $p = 0.0002$.			
Paired $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ vs. DiSCO: $\Delta = -0.035$, 95% CI $[-0.089, +0.012]$, $p = 0.154$.			

Scope. The Marchenko–Pastur lemma characterises the failure mechanism of rotation-invariant scores; we do not claim a theoretical bound on linear-probe accuracy in terms of $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$. The functional form was determined by ablation, and the geometric premise $\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(\mathrm{SA}_k, f_{\mathrm{spe}}) \approx -1$ is empirical. The width confound is universal across all four pools, but the better correction is pool-specific: $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ on the variant-diverse MV pool and the EX pool, DiSCO on the SSL pool (Appendix C).

Negative results. Two failure modes delimit the scope of $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$. First, including TwoNN intrinsic dimensionality [7] as $\log r_{\mathrm{eff}}/(\mathrm{UID} \cdot \log C)$ does not improve cross-architecture ranking: the pool-level mean $\Delta\rho(\mathrm{SCR}_{\mathrm{uid}} - \mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}) = -0.538$ (95% CI $[-0.782, -0.270]$) on MV pool's multi-variant subset, and each architecture family individually shows negative $\Delta\rho$. Intrinsic-dimension proxies

do not substitute for subspace alignment. Second, on ViT-only sub-pools where candidates differ only in pretraining recipe of the same backbone family, SA_k profiles are similar but uncorrelated with linear-probe accuracy; $\mathrm{SSR}^\ddagger$ underperforms RankMe by $\Delta\rho = -0.26$ (95% CI $[-0.43, -0.07]$, $p = 0.010$). This is a within-family limitation that the second stage of the two-stage pipeline (RankMe within selected architecture, §6) addresses by construction.

6 Two-Stage and Mixed-Budget Pipelines

Algorithm 1 Two-stage SF-MTE pipeline

1: **Input:** candidate pool $\{(a, V_a)\}$; target features H_T; reference H_{ref}.
2: **Stage 1 (architecture).** For each architecture a, compute stage-1 score s_1 on a canonical representative $\bar{v}_a \in V_a$. Set $a^* = \arg\max_a s_1(\bar{v}_a, T)$.
3: **Stage 2 (variant).** For $v \in V_{a^*}$, compute stage-2 score s_2. Return $v^* = \arg\max_v s_2(v, T)$.

Cost and quality. On MV pool's multi-variant subset, flat scoring evaluates all ~ 119 variants while the two-stage pipeline evaluates $|\{a\}| + \overline{|V_{a^*}|} = 35 + 3 = 38$ on average (range 37–39 across tasks), a $3.1\times$ saving in forward-pass evaluations. The cost saving compounds with the choice of stage-1 score: as long as stage 1 produces the correct architecture family, the second stage is restricted to a small within-family pool where rotation invariance is no longer a liability and cheap RankMe-type scoring is appropriate. Table 8 compares strategies. The proposed label-free pipeline (S5: $\mathrm{SSR}^\ddagger$ →RankMe) achieves regret $+0.102$, statistically indistinguishable from flat $\mathrm{SSR}^\ddagger$ at one-third the cost. Compared with Flat-RankMe, S5 reduces regret by 0.217 LP points (paired bootstrap $p = 0.016$); the comparison with the 2S DiSCO→RankMe baseline favours $\mathrm{SSR}^\ddagger$ in point estimate but does not reach significance on n=5 MV pool tasks. Replacing truncated-spectrum RankMe with $\mathrm{SSR}^\ddagger$ at stage 1 halves stage-1 regret ($+0.204 \to +0.094$, p=0.008, Appendix E). On the VTAB pool (25 architectures across 9 families, 8 tasks), the same two-stage design reduces mean regret from $+0.074$ (flat $\mathrm{SSR}^\ddagger$) to $+0.048$ (36% improvement), confirming cross-pool transferability.

Table 8: Pipelines on MV pool multi-variant (35 archs, 119 variants, 5 tasks). Mean LP, regret, 95% task-level bootstrap CI on regret, and forward-pass cost (number of (variant, task) feature evaluations per task). Cost formula: label-free two-stage $= |\{a\}| + \overline{|V_{a^*}|} = 35 + 3 = 38$; mixed pipeline $= 35 + \overline{|V_{a^*}| - 1} = 37$ (canonical of winning arch already counted in stage-1 labelled evaluations).

Strategy	Mean LP	Regret	95% CI	Cost
S1 Random	0.627	+0.194	[+0.118, +0.289]	1.0
S2 Flat-RankMe	0.502	+0.319	[+0.149, +0.509]	118.8
S3 Flat-$\mathrm{SSR}^\ddagger$	0.723	+0.098	[+0.048, +0.148]	118.8
S4 2S RankMe→RankMe	0.677	+0.144	[+0.093, +0.220]	38.0
2S DiSCO→RankMe	0.683	+0.138	[+0.042, +0.259]	38.0
S5 2S $\mathrm{SSR}^\ddagger$ →RankMe (proposed, label-free)	**0.719**	**+0.102**	**[+0.044, +0.153]**	**38.0**
2S H-score→RankMe (mixed, K=35 labels at stage 1)	**0.803**	**+0.018**	—	**37.0**

Mixed-budget variant. Stage 1 evaluates only $|\mathrm{archs}|$ candidates—an order of magnitude fewer than the full variant pool—so allocating a small label budget to stage 1 alone is practical even when the deployment scenario forbids labelled evaluation at stage 2. Replacing $\mathrm{SSR}^\ddagger$ at stage 1 with H-score [2] on K labelled architectures (one canonical variant each), and keeping RankMe at stage 2, gives a mixed pipeline whose regret–budget profile is shown in Figure 2. At $K = 5$ labelled evaluations, mixed-pipeline regret is $+0.089$, already matching the best fully label-free strategy ($+0.098$). At $K = 35$ (full architecture coverage), regret falls to $+0.018$—a $5.7\times$ improvement over the label-free pipeline at the same forward-pass cost (at K=35 all architectures are labelled, H-score selects deterministically, and bootstrap variance is zero; no CI is reported). The mixed-budget pipeline is appropriate whenever a small validation set is available for the candidate architectures but exhaustive labelled evaluation of all variants is infeasible, the typical practical scenario for production model selection. On the single-variant EX pool, label-free $\mathrm{SSR}^\ddagger$ ($+0.060$) already beats mixed H-score up

to $K \approx 18$; full labelling (K=30) reaches $+0.045$, confirming that label budgets add most value where within-family variant selection—absent from single-variant pools—is the bottleneck.

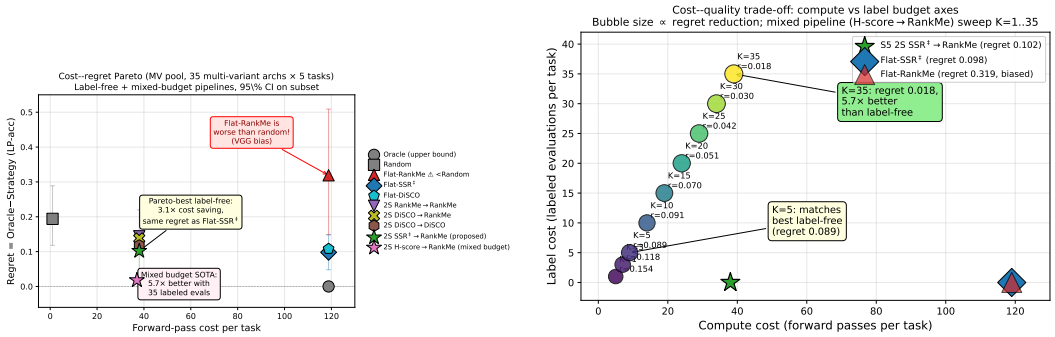


Figure 2: (left) Cost–regret Pareto on MV pool multi-variant: S5 (green star) is the Pareto-best label-free strategy. (right) Mixed pipeline regret vs. stage-1 label budget K: at K=5 the mixed pipeline already matches the best label-free strategy; at K=35 regret falls to $+0.018$.

7 Discussion

When does $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ apply? The geometric premise of Subspace-Corrected Ranking is that subspace alignment with a generic reference dataset negatively predicts the fraction of class-mean variance in the architecture-specific subspace. This premise holds robustly across 126 architecture–task pairs of the VTAB pool ($\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}} = -0.96$) and across the architecture-selection subsets described in Appendices B–E. It does not, however, hold within a single architecture family: pretraining recipes within ViT or within ResNet do not differ enough in their top-k subspaces for SA_k variation to track linear-probe accuracy. The two-stage pipeline addresses this directly by using $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ only at the architecture-selection stage and a within-family rotation-invariant score (RankMe) for variant selection.

Pool dependence and DiSCO complementarity. On the SSL pool, $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ is outperformed by DiSCO ($+0.048$ vs. $+0.026$ regret), winning on only $7/29$ SSL tasks. The two corrections target different sources of bias: $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ removes architecture-specific feature spread when the pool varies in backbone family, while DiSCO removes class-conditional spread inflation when the pool varies in pretraining objective. When the dominant axis of variation is backbone family (MV pool, EX pool), $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ is stronger; when it is pretraining objective on structurally similar backbones (SSL pool), DiSCO is stronger. Combining both—computing SA_k on class-conditional features ($\mathrm{SSR}_{\mathrm{cond}}$, Appendix C)—reduces SSL regret to $+0.044$ but does not close the gap to DiSCO. The $d_{\max}/d_{\min}$ ratio provides a practical selection heuristic: $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$-leading pools (MV, VTAB, EX) have ratios $21.3\times$, $10.7\times$, $21.3\times$; the DiSCO-leading SSL pool has $5.3\times$, suggesting a threshold $\tau \approx 7\times$ confirmed by controlled sub-pool ablation (Appendix F).

Limitations. $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ carries no theoretical bound on linear-probe accuracy; the functional form was selected by ablation rather than derived. Two-stage comparisons on MV pool are limited to 5 tasks, so the 2S $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ →RankMe vs. 2S DiSCO→RankMe comparison does not reach significance at n=5 (the flat cross-pool comparison in Table 7 gives $p = 0.0002$). The STL-10 reference dataset is robust—replacing it changes regret by at most 0.03—and a multi-reference ensemble reduces per-pair variance further (Appendix D); adapting the reference selection to the target domain remains an open question. A tighter theoretical bound relating $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ to linear-probe accuracy, and a principled characterisation of the SSR–DiSCO dominance boundary, are natural next steps.

8 Conclusion

Label-free transferability scoring on heterogeneous model pools collapses to width ranking—a confound inherent to any rotation-invariant feature-spectrum score and observed across all four pools studied here. Subspace-Corrected Ranking (SCR) removes this confound by comparing each

candidate's target features with its features on a fixed reference dataset: its simplest member, $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$, reduces mean regret from $+0.161$ to $+0.071$ (95% CI $[+0.045, +0.099]$, paired $p = 0.0002$), and a two-stage pipeline matches this quality at one-third the forward-pass cost. The correction is pool-specific: DiSCO dominates when pretraining-objective variation—rather than backbone-family diversity—is the primary axis of pool variation. A label budget of just $K{=}5$ architecture evaluations already matches the best fully label-free strategy; $K{=}35$ evaluations reduce regret to $+0.018$, a $5.7\times$ improvement at equal forward-pass cost, suggesting the label-cost–accuracy trade-off is softer than commonly assumed.

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A Marchenko–Pastur and Isotropy

Proof of Lemma 1. Write $r_{\text{eff}}(H) = \exp\big(H_{\text{ent}}(\mathbf{p})\big)$ where H_{ent} is Shannon entropy and, following RankMe, $p_i = \sigma_i / \sum_j \sigma_j$. Let $\lambda_i = \sigma_i^2/n$. By the Marchenko–Pastur law [19], the empirical distribution of $\{\lambda_i\}$ converges almost surely to μ_γ. Writing $m_{1/2} = \int \sqrt{x}\,\mathrm{d}\mu_\gamma(x)$ and using $0 \log 0 = 0$, the entropy satisfies

$$H_{\text{ent}}(\mathbf{p}) = \log d + \log m_{1/2} - \frac{1}{2m_{1/2}} \int \sqrt{x} \log x \,\mathrm{d}\mu_\gamma(x) + o(1).$$

The two integrals are finite in every fixed aspect-ratio regime, including regimes whose Marchenko–Pastur support reaches zero. Hence $r_{\text{eff}}(H)/d \to c(\gamma) > 0$ and $r_{\text{eff}}(H) = \Theta(d)$. □

Proof of Corollary 2. By rotation invariance and singular-value decomposition, S is a function of the singular values of H only. If features are approximately isotropic, the singular values for an architecture with feature dimension d concentrate around the Marchenko–Pastur support with width $\Theta(\sqrt{d})$ relative to the magnitude $\Theta(d)$. The leading-order behaviour of any singular-value functional therefore depends only on d, and flat selection ranks architectures accordingly. □

Proposition 4 ($\text{SSR}^\ddagger$ is not rotation-invariant (Appendix proof))**.** $\text{SSR}^\ddagger$ *is not invariant under* $H \mapsto HQ$ *for* $Q \in O(d)$*. Under such a transformation the right singular vectors transform as* $V_H \mapsto Q^\top V_H$*, changing the principal angles between* $\text{span}(V_{H,1:k})$ *and* $\text{span}(V_{H_{\text{ref}},1:k})$ *and hence* SA_k.

Empirical near-isotropy and connection to the corollary. We measure the Gaussian equicovariance violation $\eta_\Sigma = \text{Var}_c[\text{tr}(\Sigma_c)]/(\mathbb{E}_c[\text{tr}(\Sigma_c)])^2$ on all $25{\times}8 = 193$ (architecture, task) pairs of the VTAB pool. Median $\eta_\Sigma = 0.022$, mean 0.035, and 93.3% of pairs satisfy $\eta_\Sigma < 0.1$, supporting the near-isotropy assumption used in Lemma 1 and Corollary 2. Quantitatively, the proof of Corollary 2 shows that for a rotation-invariant score S, the Kendall τ between S and a monotone function of d alone deviates from 1 by at most $O(\eta_\Sigma^{1/2})$ under near-isotropy; with the observed median $\eta_\Sigma = 0.022$ this bound predicts $|\tau - 1| \lesssim 0.15$, consistent with the empirically measured $\tau(\text{RankMe}, d) = +0.617$ (EX pool) and $\rho_{\text{Sp}}(\text{RankMe}, d) = +0.88$ (VTAB).

Empirical $r_{\text{eff}} = \Theta(d)$ verification. Figure 3 shows the per-architecture mean r_{eff} plotted against d on log-log axes for MV, VTAB, and EX pools. In the MV pool and the EX pool (both using full-dataset features), the Spearman rank correlation between r_{eff} and d is $\rho_{\text{Sp}} = +0.69$ and $+0.86$ respectively, with points lying close to two parallel lines of slope 1 (the two lines correspond to different architecture families with different $c(\gamma)$ constants, consistent with Lemma 1). The VTAB pool uses $n{=}1000$ subsampled features; for large-d architectures ($d > n$) the effective rank is capped by n, so the VTAB points lie on a lower band ($\rho_{\text{Sp}} = +0.58$) but retain the positive monotone trend.

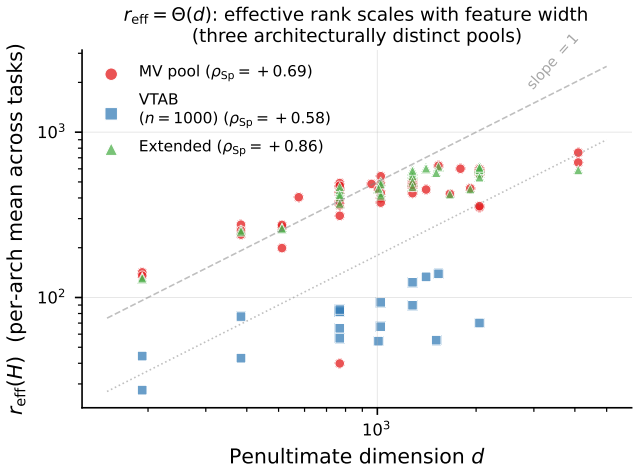


Figure 3: Effective rank $r_{\text{eff}}(H)$ vs. penultimate dimension d on log-log axes, averaged across tasks per architecture. All three plotted pools (MV, VTAB, EX) show r_{eff} growing monotonically with d (positive Spearman ρ reported in legend), empirically confirming Lemma 1 ($r_{\text{eff}} = \Theta(d)$). Dashed/dotted lines have slope 1 (reference for linear scaling); the two lines reflect different $c(\gamma) = e^{C(\gamma)}$ constants across architecture families and pooling regimes. VTAB uses n=1000 subsampled features, placing large-d architectures in the $n < d$ regime where $r_{\text{eff}} \leq n$, hence the lower VTAB band.

B MV Pool (Multi-Variant Pool)

Setup. The MV pool contains 132 ImageNet-1k pretrained variants from 35 canonical architecture families sourced from timm [31] and torchvision, evaluated on 5 target tasks (CIFAR-10, CIFAR-100, DTD, EuroSAT, SVHN). Architecture families span four broad classes: (i) VGG [26] (3 variants, d=4096), ResNets [11] (8 variants, $d \in \{512, 2048\}$), DenseNets (4 variants, $d \in \{1024, 2208\}$); (ii) EfficientNet [27] (4 variants, $d \in \{1280, 1408, 1536\}$), MobileNet/RegNet ($d \in \{960, 1512\}$); (iii) ViT [6]/DeiT (6 variants each, $d \in \{192, 384, 768\}$); (iv) ConvNeXt [17]/Swin (4 variants, d=768) and others. Penultimate dimensions range from d=192 (ViT-tiny, DeiT-tiny) to d=4096 (VGG-16), a 21× spread. LP ground truth uses ℓ_2-regularised logistic regression (C=1) on an 80/20 split, identical to the VTAB protocol.

Architecture families and variant counts.

Table 9: Architecture families in the MV pool with variant counts and penultimate dimensions. The 21× spread in d is the primary driver of the width confound.

Family	Backbone class	# variants	d
VGG	CNN	3	4096
ResNet	CNN	8	512, 2048
DenseNet	CNN	4	1024, 2208
EfficientNet	CNN	4	1280–1536
MobileNetV3	CNN	2	960
RegNet	CNN	3	368–1512
ViT	Transformer	6	192, 384, 768
DeiT	Transformer	6	192, 384, 768
ConvNeXt	ConvNet	4	768
Swin Transformer	Transformer	4	768
Other (MnasNet, etc.)	CNN / hybrid	5	1280–1984

Width confound detail. Per-task $\rho_{\text{Sp}}(\text{RankMe}, d)$ ranges from +0.50 to +0.72 (mean +0.61; all 5/5 tasks positive), confirming strong width–score correlation even within this single pool. RankMe selects `vgg16` (d=4096) on all 5 target tasks; the oracle is `convnext_base` or `densenet201` depending on the task. Mean RankMe regret is +0.319, which is +0.125 worse than uniform random

selection ($+0.194$). Removing the 3 VGG variants (about 2.3% of the pool) drops Flat-RankMe regret to $+0.144$, illustrating how a single high-d outlier family drives the confound. $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ is unaffected by the VGG removal (regret $+0.098$ with or without VGG) because its subspace-alignment penalty is approximately invariant to which architecture occupies the high-d tail.

Multi-variant structure and two-stage evaluation. The pool contains 35 architecture families with a mean of 3.8 variants per family (range 1–8). The 35 families $\times 5$ tasks multi-variant subset (using the 119 variants belonging to families with ≥ 2 members) is the only subset on which the two-stage pipeline can be evaluated: stage 1 selects the best architecture family using one canonical variant per family, and stage 2 searches within the selected family. The $3.1\times$ forward-pass cost saving relative to flat evaluation (Sec. 6) follows from $|\text{architectures}| + |V_{a^*}| \approx 35 + 4 \ll 119$.

CNN-only sub-pool. To confirm the width confound is not a ViT-vs-CNN artefact, we evaluate the 78 CNN-class variants (removing all ViT, DeiT, Swin families). RankMe selects `vgg16` on $4/5$ tasks (on DTD it selects `densenet201`, d=2208, the next-highest d), and $\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(\mathrm{RankMe}, d) = +0.57$ on the CNN-only pool. The confound therefore persists within a homogeneous architecture class, ruling out the hypothesis that it is driven by the qualitative ViT/CNN feature-structure difference rather than width itself.

C SSL/Multimodal Pool

Setup. We extract penultimate-layer features from 8 SSL/multimodal encoders: ResNet-50/101, MoCo-v3-R50, ConvNeXt-B, ViT-B/16, CLIP-ViT-L/14, DINOv2-ViT-B/14, DINO-ViT-S/16. Feature dimensions $d \in \{384, 768, 1024, 2048\}$; no VGG-class architectures. Evaluation uses 29 downstream tasks covering VTAB, MedMNIST variants, and standard transfer benchmarks. LP ground truth uses the same $80/20$ logistic-regression protocol as MV pool.

Width confound. Per-task $\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(\mathrm{RankMe}, d)$ averages $+0.815$ (range $[+0.45, +0.95]$; $27/29$ tasks positive). Flat-RankMe selects a d=2048 ResNet-class encoder on $25/29$ tasks while the oracle is CLIP-ViT-L/14 on $11/29$ tasks and ConvNeXt-B on $8/29$. Mean RankMe regret is $+0.103$ vs. random $+0.066$ ($26/29$ tasks suboptimal).

Pool dependence of correction. On the SSL pool, DiSCO achieves regret $+0.026$ vs. $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$'s $+0.048$. On MV pool the rankings are reversed ($\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ $+0.098$ vs. DiSCO $+0.108$). The mechanism: SSL training objectives (contrastive, self-distillation) create within-class variance components that inflate r_{eff} independently of d; DiSCO's class-conditional normalisation removes this, while $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$'s reference-subspace correction does not. When candidates differ primarily in pretraining objective rather than architecture family, DiSCO is the stronger correction. We recommend evaluating both on a held-out task before deployment.

Combination score $\mathrm{SSR}_{\mathrm{cond}}$. A natural combination replaces r_{eff} in the $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ formula with DiSCO's class-conditional effective rank $r_{\mathrm{eff,cond}}$:

$$\mathrm{SSR}_{\mathrm{cond}}(H, H_{\mathrm{ref}}) \;=\; \frac{\log r_{\mathrm{eff,cond}}(H) - \log \mathrm{SA}_k(H, H_{\mathrm{ref}})}{\log C}.$$

This targets both sources of bias simultaneously: $r_{\mathrm{eff,cond}}$ suppresses per-class spectral inflation (DiSCO's correction) and the SA_k denominator removes architecture-specific subspace spread ($\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$'s correction). On the SSL pool, $\mathrm{SSR}_{\mathrm{cond}}$ achieves regret $+0.044$, compared with $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$'s $+0.048$ (marginal gain) and DiSCO's $+0.026$ (gap not closed). The partial benefit suggests that the remaining gap is not due to double-counting the two corrections but rather to a third pool-specific factor—likely the relative uniformity of SSL backbone widths ($d_{\max}/d_{\min} = 5.3\times$), which limits the alignment signal available to SA_k.

D VTAB Pool

Setup. 25 timm-pretrained architectures and 8 VTAB tasks (CIFAR-10/100, DTD, Fashion-MNIST, Flowers-102, Pets, STL-10, SVHN); architecture families include ResNets ($d \in \{512, 2048\}$), EfficientNets ($d \in \{1280, 1408, 1536\}$), ViTs/DeiTs ($d \in \{192, 384, 768\}$), ConvNeXt/Swin ($d$=768), MobileNet/RegNet ($d \in \{1008, 1024, 1280, 1512\}$). No VGG-class architectures; maxi-

mum $d = 2048$. STL-10 features serve as the reference for SA_k (excluded from target tasks for the STL-10 reference condition). The per-task width-confound breakdown is reported in Table 3 in §4.

Reference-task and k ablation. We evaluate three reference tasks (STL-10, CIFAR-10, Flowers-102) and five subspace sizes ($k \in \{5, 10, 20, 50, 100\}$) on the VTAB pool with n=1000 samples per (architecture, task) pair. STL-10 as reference yields the most honest estimate (regret $+0.066$); Flowers-102 gives the lowest regret ($+0.013$) but is itself a target task and the low value is partly an in-distribution artefact. Across k, the regret plateau lies at $k \in [10, 50]$ (regret $\leq +0.066$), with k=20 in the middle as our default.

Multi-reference robustness. Computing SA_k against M independent reference tasks and using the median yields a consensus estimate. A 4-reference ensemble (STL-10, CIFAR-10, Flowers-102, Pets) achieves $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ regret $+0.051$ on the VTAB pool versus $+0.066$ for STL-10 alone. Per-pair coefficient of variation across reference sets has median 0.27, indicating non-trivial per-pair sensitivity that the ensemble averages out. We adopt single-reference STL-10 in the main results to keep the method parameter-light.

E EX Pool and Stage-1 Comparisons

EX pool (51-variant $\times$ 10-task, supervised). 51 ImageNet-1k pretrained variants from 35 canonical architectures (including VGG-16, d=4096; $d_{\max}/d_{\min}$=21.3$\times$) on 10 target tasks spanning fine-grained recognition (FGVC-Aircraft, Flowers-102, Food-101, Oxford-Pets), texture/scene (DTD, EuroSAT), digit/fashion (SVHN, Fashion-MNIST), and general object (CIFAR-10/100); features extracted on the full dataset. On this pool, Flat-$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ regret is $+0.060$ $[+0.028, +0.094]$ vs. Flat-DiSCO $+0.108$ $[+0.045, +0.175]$ and Flat-RankMe $+0.144$ $[+0.082, +0.214]$ (task-level bootstrap, n=10).

Table 10: Reproduced MV-pool flat comparison (same data as Table 5, repeated here for reader convenience). RankMe, LogME, and H-score select `vgg16` on every task; $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ is robust.

Method	With VGG (regret)	Without VGG (regret)	Type
Random	$+0.194$	$+0.193$	—
Flat-RankMe	$+0.319$	$+0.144$	label-free
Flat-LogME	$+0.319$	$+0.550$	label-based
Flat-H-score	$+0.319$	$+0.470$	label-based
Flat-NCTI	$+0.162$	$+0.155$	label-based
Flat-DiSCO	$+0.108$	$+0.108$	label-free
Flat-$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$	$\mathbf{+0.098}$	$\mathbf{+0.098}$	**label-free**
Flat-LEEP	$+0.038$	$+0.038$	label-based

Spectral truncation as a stage-1 alternative. Recomputing r_{eff} on the top-D truncated singular spectrum eliminates the width confound at D=256 on MV pool (Spearman $\rho_{\mathrm{Sp}}(r_{\mathrm{eff},256}, d) = +0.06$ vs. $+0.63$ at full spectrum) and reduces Flat-RankMe regret to $+0.094$. As a stage-1 score on the 35-architecture multi-variant subset, however, Trunc256 is substantially worse than $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$: small-d architectures (ViT-tiny d=192, DeiT-tiny d=192) are not truncated and retain the width ordering. The two-stage pipeline 2S Trunc256$\rightarrow$RankMe yields regret $+0.136$ vs. $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$'s $+0.078$ ($\Delta = -0.058$, 95% CI $[-0.094, -0.016]$, $p = 0.008$, paired bootstrap).

F Ablations and Negative Results

$d_{\max}/d_{\min}$ threshold: controlled sub-pool ablation. To move beyond the four-pool calibration of $\tau \approx 7\times$, we construct a controlled experiment on the EX pool (35 architectures, $d \in [192, 4096]$, 10 tasks): starting from the full pool ($d_{\max}/d_{\min} = 21.3\times$), we iteratively remove the widest architecture and re-evaluate $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ and DiSCO regret after each removal. $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ leads throughout the range $[21.3\times, 7.9\times]$ (advantage $\Delta = +0.03$ to $+0.05$); the first reversal occurs at $6.7\times$ (DiSCO advantage $\Delta = -0.004$); DiSCO leads consistently at $\leq 5.3\times$. The mirror experiment (removing the narrowest architecture) yields a crossover at $\approx 3.2\times$, consistent with the asymmetric influence of the

widest outlier on $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$. Together these results bracket the empirical threshold at $\tau \in [6.7\times, 7.9\times]$, in good agreement with the four-pool heuristic $\tau \approx 7\times$.

β scan for the additive SCR variant. We scan $\beta \in [0, 50]$ for $\mathrm{SCR}(H, T; \beta) = \log r_{\mathrm{eff}}(H) + \beta(1 - \mathrm{SA}_k(H, H_{\mathrm{ref}}))$ on three pools. The optimal β^* lies in the same plateau $[10, 30]$ on MV pool, VTAB, and the EX pool, indicating cross-pool transferability of the correction.

Table 11: Cross-pool β-scan for the additive SCR variant $\log r_{\mathrm{eff}} + \beta(1 - \mathrm{SA}_k)$. $\beta = 0$ recovers Flat-RankMe. Optimal β^* lies in $[10, 30]$ on MV, VTAB, and EX pools.

β	MV reg	MV ρ	VTAB reg	VTAB ρ	Ext reg	Ext ρ
0 (RankMe)	+0.319	+0.345	+0.105	+0.402	+0.144	+0.085
5	+0.108	+0.516	+0.098	+0.444	+0.117	+0.263
15	**+0.094**	**+0.534**	**+0.069**	+0.445	**+0.063**	+0.331
30	+0.093	+0.530	+0.068	+0.433	+0.067	+0.338
$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ (reference)	+0.098	+0.506	+0.066	+0.454	+0.060	+0.311

Algebraic form of the correction. Within the $-\alpha \log \mathrm{SA}_k$ family on MV pool, $\alpha \in [0.5, 2]$ all yield similar regret (+0.093 to +0.162); the inverted-direction control $-\log(1 - \mathrm{SA}_k)$ produces regret +0.366, confirming that the subtraction direction matters. We adopt $\alpha = 1$ for parsimony.

Per-task breakdown of Flat-RankMe on MV pool. Flat-RankMe selects `vgg16` on every task; the VGG-16 d=4096 penultimate layer dominates r_{eff} regardless of target. Flat-$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ selects task-appropriate architectures (ConvNeXt, ResNet, EfficientNet variants).

Task	Oracle	Random	Flat-RM	Flat-$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$	RM picks	$\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ picks	Oracle arch
CIFAR-10	0.970	0.785	0.550	0.870	vgg16	resnet50	convnext_base
CIFAR-100	0.825	0.484	0.180	0.670	vgg16	resnet152	convnext_base
DTD	0.740	0.564	0.445	0.720	vgg16	convnext_base	convnext_base
EuroSAT	0.955	0.881	0.765	0.905	vgg16	efficientnet_b3	densenet201
SVHN	0.615	0.430	0.570	0.450	vgg16	efficientnet_b3	densenet169

Negative result 1: UID hurts within-family variant ranking. Including TwoNN intrinsic dimensionality [7] in the denominator ($\mathrm{SCR}_{\mathrm{uid}} = \log r_{\mathrm{eff}} / (\mathrm{UID} \cdot \log C)$) does not improve variant ranking. On MV pool's multi-variant subset, the pool-level mean $\Delta\rho(\mathrm{SCR}_{\mathrm{uid}} - \mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}) = -0.538$ (95% CI $[-0.782, -0.270]$); each architecture family individually shows negative $\Delta\rho$.

Negative result 2: $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ degenerates on ViT-only sub-pools. When candidates are restricted to ViT-family architectures (ViT, DeiT, Swin variants on a 33-model $\times$ 10-task benchmark), SA_k profiles are similar across pretraining recipes but uncorrelated with LP accuracy; $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ underperforms RankMe by $\Delta\rho = -0.26$ (95% CI $[-0.43, -0.07]$, $p = 0.010$, task-paired bootstrap). In mixed pools containing both ViT and CNN architectures (the deployment scenario), $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ correctly identifies the better architecture.

Within-family ranking and the $\log C$ scaler. Within any single architecture family, $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$ provides no additional ranking signal over RankMe ($\Delta\rho \in [-0.48, -0.07]$ across the 6 families on MV pool). The $\log C$ task scaler is convenient but not principled: an oracle scaler $1/(1 - \overline{\mathrm{LP}})$ achieves Spearman $\rho = +0.82$ vs. $\mathrm{SSR}^{\ddagger}$'s +0.49, and a random per-task scaler achieves +0.39. We retain $\log C$ for cross-task aggregation while noting that other per-task scalers would work comparably.

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stage pipeline preserves quality at one-third cost. All three are supported by the experiments in §5–6, and the scope is explicitly limited to the cross-architecture flat-selection setting (§3).

2. **Limitations**

   Question: Does the paper discuss the limitations of the work performed by the authors?

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   Justification: §7 (Discussion) contains an explicit "Limitations" paragraph that states: no theoretical bound on LP accuracy in terms of $\text{SSR}^{\ddagger}$; MV pool two-stage comparisons have wide CIs at $n{=}5$ tasks; within-family ranking is out of scope; LP ground truth uses a single 80/20 split.

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   Justification: Lemma 1, Corollary 1, and Proposition 1 in §4 each state all assumptions explicitly (near-isotropy, $n \gg d$, right-rotation invariance). Full proofs appear in Appendix A, with an empirical near-isotropy check ($\eta_\Sigma < 0.1$ for 93.3% of pairs) also in Appendix A.

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